royal control, his favorite brother, Louis of Orleans, and his uncle, the seventy-year-old Duke of Burgundy, were feuding. Both hoped to control the mad king, and through him, France.

In 1404, the Duke of Burgundy died and his part of the feud devolved to his son and heir John, newly returned from the Battle of Nicopolis and ransomed from Turkish captivity. The new Duke rapidly gained both power and popularity. He managed to arrange a match between his eleven-year-old daughter and the young Dauphin Louis, Charles VI's son and heir (despite his fits, Charles had been married since the age of seventeen, and by 1404 his wife Isabeau had borne him eight children). "A very heavy tax was about this time imposed on all the inhabitants throughout France, by the king and his council at Paris," writes the chronicler Enguerrand de Monstrelet, "but the Duke of Burgundy would not consent that it should be levied—which conduct gained him universal popularity throughout the kingdom."[5]

This only intensified the Duke of Orleans's "deep hatred" for his cousin, and over the next three years the two men jockeyed unceasingly for power: ingratiating themselves with the people of Paris by way of public grants and tax breaks, demanding special favors from the king, insisting on the command of various expeditions against France's foes.

In 1407, on the Feast of Saint Clement—November 23—the Duke of Orleans was ambushed in the streets of Paris, late at night, by a gang of armed men. He was knocked off his horse and beaten to death in the street so savagely that, the next morning, his servants went back to scrape up the brain matter that had been scattered across the stones so that it could be buried with him; they also found his right hand, which had been severed in the attack.[6]

The ambushers had been hired by the Duke of Burgundy, which soon became clear when several of them bragged about the murder. "This was the cause of most disastrous quarrels," says Monstrelet, "which lasted a very long time, insomuch that the kingdom was nearly ruined and overturned." Fearing arrest, the Duke of Burgundy fled from Paris and made his way back to his own domains. But even with the truth of the assassination out, he remained popular. "The Parisians [had not been] well pleased with the Duke of Orleans," Monstrelet adds, "for they had learnt that he was the author of all the heavy taxes that oppressed them, and began to say among themselves in secret, 'The knotty stick is smoothed.'"[7]

Early in the spring, the Duke of Burgundy boldly returned to Paris and, with the help of the noted theologian Jehan Petit, mounted a public defense. The killing, he and Petit argued, was not murder, but tyrannicide, and so was both ethical and justified. Jehan Petit offered a syllogism to defend it (along with four hours of detailed supporting argumentation):